Local Research Paper Library with Airflow

Technical Report — INFO-H420, Assignment 3

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A single-machine pipeline converts research PDFs into a searchable study library. Apache Airflow orchestrates PDF conversion, local LLM inference, metadata storage, HTML generation, Google Drive transfers, and Discord notifications. The processing logic is implemented in Python and runs in Ubuntu through WSL2.

Result: the complete Drive-to-Discord run succeeded for two new PDFs. The library contained four stored papers, and four pending notifications were confirmed. Subsequent runs found no new inputs and completed without repeating inference or notification delivery.

1. ARCHITECTURE AND DESIGN

The `paper_pipeline` DAG runs through `airflow standalone` on a five-minute schedule. It contains nine task definitions. Conversion, extraction, and storage are dynamically mapped over the new papers discovered at runtime; a failure watcher is connected to every stage. Both DAG concurrency and executor parallelism are limited to one task, allowing CPU inference to run without competing requests.

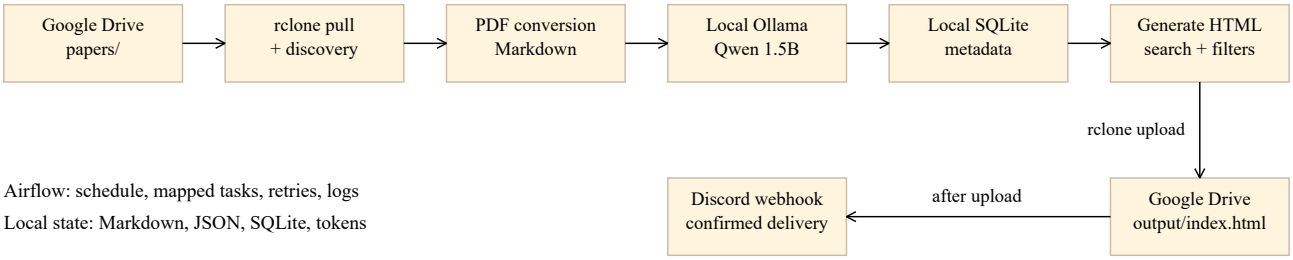


Figure 1. Logical architecture. Airflow coordinates execution; the failure watcher's monitoring connections are omitted for clarity.

Key design choices. PyMuPDF4LLM produces Markdown for text-based PDFs. Ollama serves `qwen2.5:1.5b` with Q4_K_M quantization locally; the native HTTP API provides JSON-schema output and inference timing counters. Python parses the response with `json.loads()` and checks the required title, summary, keywords, and category fields. SQLite provides transactional persistence with a unique filename key. A static HTML page supplies browser-side search, category filtering, and relative PDF links without a separate application server.

Drive integration uses non-deleting rclone operations: `copy` downloads PDFs before discovery, and `copyto` uploads only the generated page after publication. Discord delivery follows a successful upload. Desktop-synced folders use the same processing pipeline with rclone disabled. Folder paths and runtime settings are configured in `.env`; Windows paths are translated into WSL paths.

2. STATE, RETRIES, AND OBSERVABILITY

The application database, `data/papers.db`, stores paper metadata, the source checksum, processing time, and notification confirmation time. Airflow's separate database records DAG runs and task states. Intermediate Markdown and validated JSON are written atomically and retained as checkpoints. A retry of a completed save cannot insert a duplicate record, and a later publication or notification failure does not require another LLM call.

Discovery skips stored filenames, defers empty or recently modified files for ten seconds, and checks the source checksum before and after conversion. Invalid model output receives one additional request. Other stages retry once after 30 seconds. Publication can include successful database commits when another paper fails, while the failure watcher preserves an overall failed DAG status. A failed Drive download blocks the upload and notification stages.

Discord uses `wait=true` and records `notified_at` only after message creation is confirmed. Confirmed notifications are skipped on later runs. A crash after Discord accepts a message but before SQLite records the confirmation can still cause a duplicate; delivery is not exactly-once across the two systems.

Application logs identify stage transitions and filenames. During inference, 15-second heartbeats report elapsed time. Airflow adds run, task, mapped index, and attempt information. These logs distinguish an empty scan, an active LLM request, a task failure, and a task waiting for the scheduler.

3. EXECUTION AND RESULTS

The evaluated run was `scheduled__2026-10-31T13:35:00+00:00`, with execution from 13:36:58 to 13:48:11 UTC. It imported two previously unprocessed PDFs from Drive. All eleven processing task instances succeeded; the twelfth instance, the failure watcher, was correctly skipped.

Input	Pages	Prompt tokens	Extraction task duration	Result
`3793655.3793738.pdf` — Android-to-iOS agentic translation experience report	11	15,951	204.19 s	Metadata validated and stored
`AIware_in_the_Foundation_Model_Era.pdf`	5	1,732	21.84 s	Metadata validated and stored

Both responses passed JSON validation on the first attempt. The generated page contained four papers: the two new inputs and the previously stored MapReduce and Attention papers. Drive upload succeeded, and the Discord task confirmed four pending notifications, including the two earlier papers' backlog.

The run's wall time was **673.06 seconds**, including time when the DAG was manually paused. The sum of successful task execution durations was **240.57 seconds**, measured from Airflow task start/end timestamps. Wall time therefore includes an operator delay and should not be used as an uninterrupted processing-throughput measurement. Follow-up scheduled runs completed in **9.93 seconds** and **12.13 seconds**, with no new inputs or repeated LLM work. All four database records had notification confirmation timestamps.

The CPU baseline used an AMD Ryzen 9 5900HX, eight inference threads, a 32,768-token context, and a 512-token output limit. The earlier full-paper MapReduce benchmark took approximately **141 seconds** for conversion plus first inference and used approximately **2 GiB** for the model process. Zero GPU memory was allocated. Repeated requests took about ten seconds because their prompt was cached; those values do not represent processing a new paper.

The automated suite contains **35 passing tests**, covering metadata validation, bounded retries, duplicate prevention, checkpoint reuse, source changes, HTML escaping, environment loading, Windows path conversion, Drive transfer boundaries, and notification recovery. A separate invalid-PDF run confirmed that conversion failure remains visible in the DAG even when HTML publication succeeds.

4. LIMITATIONS AND REPRODUCTION

Schema-constrained JSON controls structure, not factual accuracy. The small model produced a correct title for the translation report but incorrectly renamed the AIware input to “Mindware: A Future Paradigm for Autonomous Agents in Software Engineering.” Basic validation accepted this because it checks field presence and types. Source-grounded title extraction and semantic checks are therefore useful future improvements; generated metadata must be reviewed against the PDF.

Initial scope covers text-based PDFs that fit the configured context. Scanned documents need OCR, and longer papers need a chunking strategy. Filenames are treated as unique, append-only identifiers. Local-only papers must also be placed in Drive if their PDF links are to be available to someone downloading the shared library. OAuth tokens and webhook credentials remain outside version control.

The repository README contains installation, startup, configuration, and test commands. The workflow runs with `scripts/serve_cpu.sh` and `scripts/start_airflow.sh`; `scripts/show_progress.py` follows application events. The implementation, configuration template, test suite, and supporting execution evidence are available in the linked repository.

APPENDIX A. WORKFLOW AND DRIVE EVIDENCE

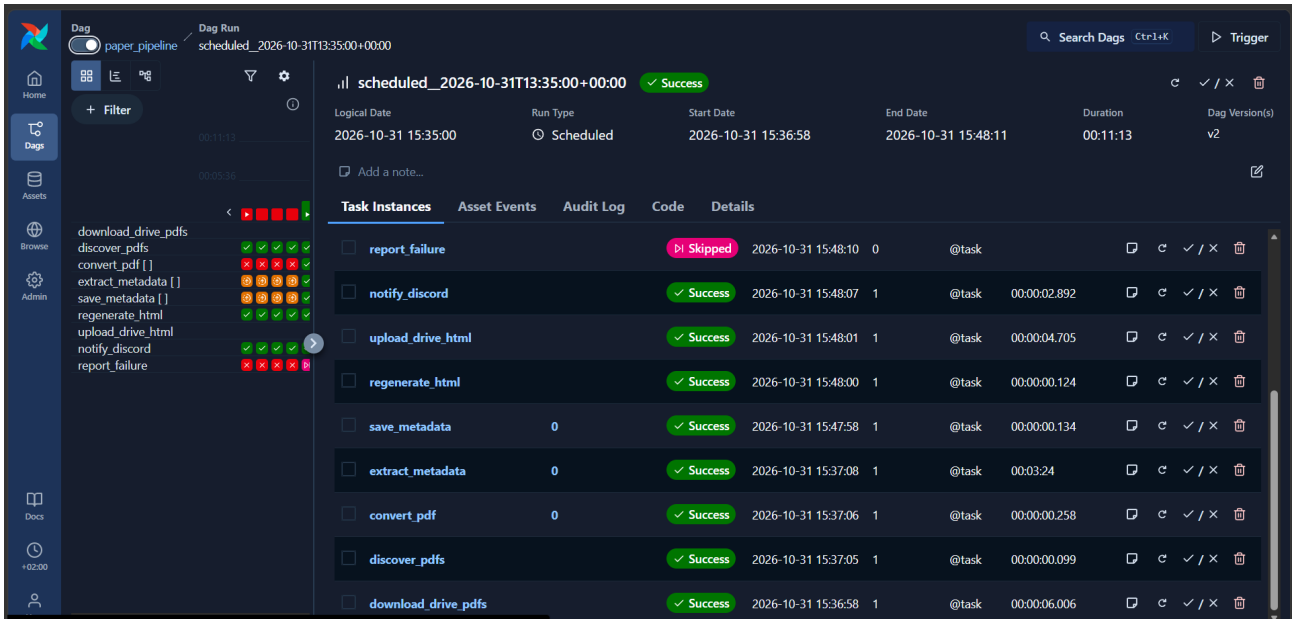


Figure 2. Successful Drive-to-Discord run, including extraction, storage, publication, and notification. The failure watcher is intentionally skipped. Dashboard timestamps use UTC+02:00; the run identifier uses UTC.

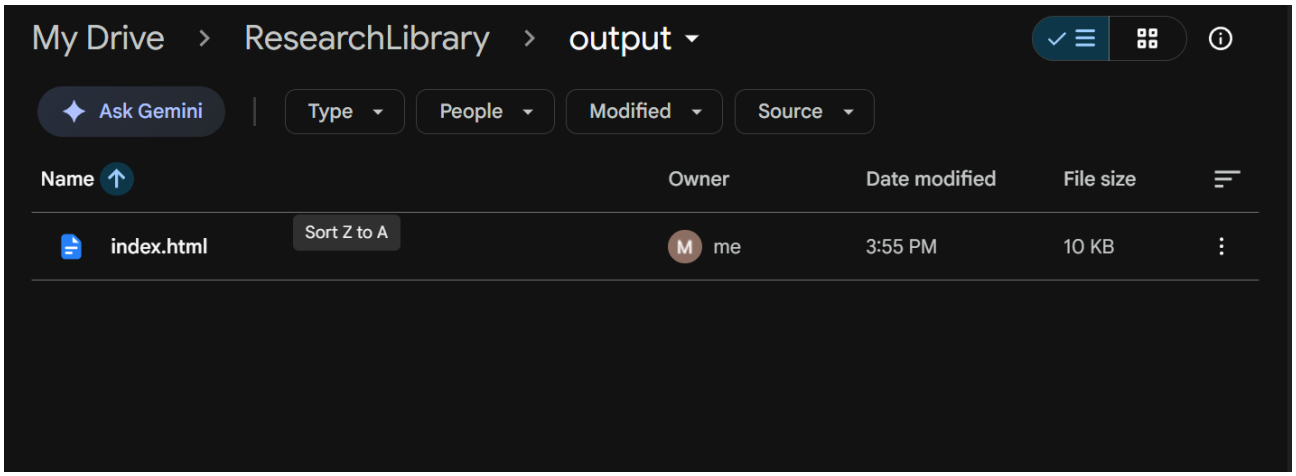


Figure 3. The generated index.html uploaded to ResearchLibrary/output in Google Drive. SQLite, intermediate files, credentials, and model weights remain local.

APPENDIX B. LIBRARY AND NOTIFICATION EVIDENCE



Figure 4. The generated page lists four papers and provides search and category filtering. The model-generated AIware title illustrates the quality limitation discussed in Section 4.

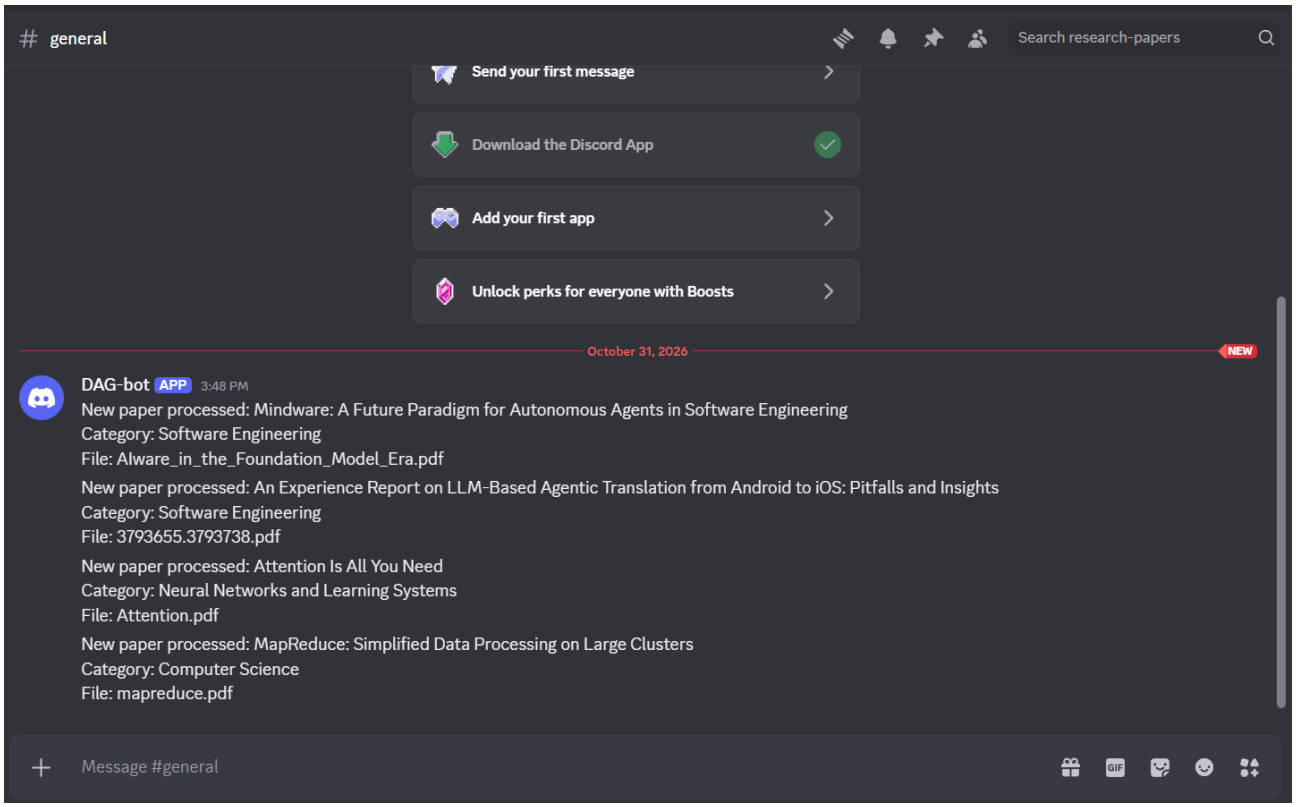


Figure 5. DAG-bot notifications for both new inputs and the previously stored Attention and MapReduce papers. Delivery confirmation is recorded in SQLite.

Additional run-history evidence is available in screenshots/02-airflow-runs.png.